Pakistani nuclear bomb A.Q. Khan hawked his wares for years before my group at the CIA caught him red-handed and put him out of business for selling a nuclear bomb to Libya in late 2003.'[6]

There has practically been no bilateral military-to-military interaction between India and Pakistan except for the posting of defence attachés, weekly DGMO-level talks, and flag meetings by the formation commanders for resolving local issues. There is some interaction between the representatives of the armed forces during the composite dialogue process, which too is now on a 'pause mode'. It may be a good idea if, as part of our overall diplomatic strategy, our defence forces are given the opportunity to break the ice and meet their contemporaries formally or informally to thrash out some of our military-related irritants. This out-of-the-box idea to engage with their army is certainly worth trying. A moderate, peaceful and prosperous Pakistan would be good for all of us, and be able to contribute to the stability of our region.

Our policy of helping in the reconstruction of Afghanistan and a development-oriented partnership has been hugely appreciated by the people of that country. We would like to see a stable and peaceful Afghanistan that would be able to establish its control and prevent the spread of terrorism by organizations like Al Qaida from its soil. An interesting conversation regarding Afghanistan took place between Dr Henry Kissinger and me at a private dinner in November 2008, when the gracious host, K.P. Singh, requested me to give company to the distinguished Nobel laureate.

Dr Kissinger began with the question, 'General, what are your views on the Afghan situation and what we should do?'

'Briefly Sir, Afghanistan has historically never been subjugated by any external power. The tribal chieftains or warlords are very powerful and their writ runs unchallenged. Nothing can be achieved without their support. You have to have them on your side. Having beaten the Russians, the Taliban and Al Qaida have their tails up,' I replied, and Dr Kissinger nodded.